Developing Your Communication Skills

From R. Martens and R.S. Vealey, *Successful Coaching*, 5th ed. (Champaign, IL: Human Kinetics, 2024), 68-76.

The first big challenge to enhancing our communication is to become aware of our personal communication deficiencies. We thought a lighthearted look at common communication short-comings of coaches might help you recognize any deficiencies in how you communicate with your athletes and staff.

In this section, we address each of these deficiencies by discussing ways in which you can become a better communicator as a coach. Our focus is on the first seven communication challenges portrayed by our mythical coaches. We suggest enhancing your communication with the following:

1. Developing credibility when you communicate
2. Communicating with a positive approach
3. Sending messages high in information
4. Communicating with consistency
5. Learning how to listen
6. Improving your nonverbal communication
7. Maintaining high expectations of all athletes regardless of skill level

Developing Credibility When You Communicate

Your credibility is probably the single most important element in communicating effectively with your athletes. Your communication credibility is reflected in the degree to which your athletes believe and trust what you say. At the outset, athletes will give you credibility simply because you occupy the prestigious role of the coach. From then on, however, you maintain and build this credibility or diminish it based on your actions and communication.

Consider this example: Coach Lee was having a bad day. At breakfast, she got into an argument with her daughter about the mess in the kitchen. At work, her boss reprimanded her for failing to complete an assignment on time, and when she arrived at the soccer field for the game, the officials were late. Then in the first period when an official failed to call a tripping foul, Coach Lee let the day's frustrations loose by charging onto the field complaining bitterly until the official ejected her from the game. Later in the locker room, after reflecting on the incident, Coach Lee apologized to the team for her actions. She explained her difficult day and that she had lost control and demonstrated poor sporting behavior. She asked that her players not follow her example but instead learn from her mistake. That went a long way in enhancing the credibility of Coach Lee with her players.

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Recommendations for Gaining Credibility

1. Be genuine and develop your authentic cooperative coaching style. Credibility is gained by being genuine, which makes you trustworthy. U.S. soccer player Carli Lloyd (2016, p. 98) said this about Coach Jill Ellis: "I have felt a special connection with Jill from the start. She's an authentic person, and I trust her completely. When she tells me something, I know it's motivated only by her desire to make me a better player." In a study of "great coaches," an important characteristic was their humanness in being unafraid to make mistakes, show faults or emotions, or admit that they did not have all the answers (Becker, 2009).
2. Regulate your emotions to help athletes regulate theirs. Coaches should show the emotional "face" that their teams need to see in all situations. No matter what emotion you're expressing, the goal is to outwardly display control. A good strategy is to mentally rehearse the type of responses you wish to show under difficult situations and even "fake it until you make it" by outwardly regulating emotions that are boiling inside.
3. Validate your athletes' feelings. Validation is showing others that you understand their thoughts and feelings. It means you're "wearing" people's feelings by showing them you are present and paying attention in a nonjudgmental way. Examples include "I can see this is very difficult for you" or "I can only imagine how hard this must be for you." As coaches, we're prone to immediately trying to fix things and offer advice. Take the time to validate your athletes' feelings first—be with them and their feelings as your first response—prior to helping them consider solutions.
4. Develop and keep up with knowledge about your sport and be honest about whatever knowledge you possess. Remember that you lose credibility and trust quickly if you try to act like you know more than you do. Be confident in what you know and don't try to fake what you don't know.
5. Attend to little things and keep your commitments. Seemingly small forms of connection and kindness are important. Use athletes' names during conversations, which draws them in and conveys the sense that you value what they have to say. Follow up difficult discussions with a supportive email (copying parents or guardians of minors if emails are not part of your professional correspondence with athletes), check in with an athlete dealing with a family emergency, or note athletes' academic achievements. Follow through on what you say you'll do. Promises kept build credibility as athletes know you are true to your word. Promises not kept erode trust.

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It's How You Say It

A small boy sat on the sidewalk holding a sign with a hat next to him. The sign read, "I am blind, please help." A man walked by and saw that there were only two coins in the hat. After reaching into his pocket and putting a few coins into the hat, he took the sign and wrote some words on it and put it back so everyone could see.

As people walked by, more and more of them put coins in the hat, and it began to fill up. Later that afternoon, the man who wrote on the sign came by to see how things were going. The boy recognized his footsteps and asked: "Are you the one who wrote on my sign?

"Yes," the man answered.

"What did you write?" the boy inquired.

"I only wrote the truth," the man said. "I said what you said, but in a different way." What he wrote was this: "Today is a beautiful day, and I cannot see it."

This story offers two lessons: First, how you communicate something can make a huge difference. The first sign simply said the boy was blind. The second sign implied to people that they were incredibly lucky not to be blind, which motivated them to be more generous. Second, you're much more likely to remember this point because of the story. Great teachers throughout history have used parables as the focus of their lessons. Stories turn the abstract into something tangible; they engage our imagination. Stories trigger emotion and hold attention. Arm yourself with a collection of stories to communicate important messages to your athletes.

Communicating With a Positive Approach

One of the most important skills you can learn, for coaching or any other aspect of life, is to communicate with a positive approach. The positive approach helps athletes value themselves as individuals, and in turn, it gives you credibility. The negative approach increases athletes' fear of failure, lowers their self-esteem, and destroys your credibility.

The positive approach emphasizes praise and reward to strengthen desirable behaviors, whereas the negative approach uses punishment and criticism to eliminate undesirable behaviors. However, being positive doesn't mean that discipline and punishment aren't needed in coaching. They are. The positive approach is just that—an overall approach—in which athletes can thrive in a supportive environment where coaches focus on catching them doing things right to shape their learning.

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Praising and rewarding athletes at appropriate times helps reinforce desirable behaviors.
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A perennial winning high school soccer coach makes a practice of calling one or two parents of her players after each game to praise the athlete's play, effort, and commitment to the team. Sometimes the calls go to parents of athletes who didn't get to play in the game. In those cases, the coach comments on their athlete's contribution to the team and provides a brief summary of the progress the athlete is making.

Recommendations for Using a Positive Approach

1. Praise should be given contingent on how each athlete performs. Athletes must earn praise, and it hurts their confidence and your credibility when they receive unearned praise from you. It is a myth that being a "positive coach" means that you spray praise around continuously and indiscriminately. Being a positive coach means you create a positive atmosphere where learning is encouraged and mistakes are part of the learning process, but praise and feedback are honest and contingent on the actual behavior of each athlete.
2. Focus on solutions to problems, as opposed to dwelling on the problem or negative aspects of a situation. Nothing hurts team morale and athletes' motivation like constant negativity. When a problem arises, acknowledge it and analyze it, but focus on the solutions and how to move forward. Mary Harvey, goalkeeper on the U.S. Women's Soccer Team that won the 1991 World Cup, gave up an easy goal just before halftime to tie up the score 1 to 1. Instead of berating her or questioning her about what happened on the goal, Coach Tony DiCicco simply talked to her about the upcoming second half and what she should focus on to prepare for that half of play. A year later, Harvey told her coach:

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> *I never told you this, but at halftime, when you didn't mention the mistake I made and simply told me what I needed to do in the second half, well, that had an unbelievable impact on me. It gave me a lot of confidence and allowed me to focus on the second half. (DiCicco & Hacker, 2002, p. 101)*

3. Adopt a mistake ritual in your team. Don't point out or dwell on the obvious when athletes make obvious mistakes. A better strategy is to brush the mistake aside with a look or gesture that says, "You're fine— you got this." A good strategy is to develop a mistake ritual for your team, which is a common gesture coaches and athletes make after mistakes to indicate that it's over, things are okay, and it's time to move on with the next play. Examples include conveying "no sweat" by wiping two fingers across your brow, "brush off" by brushing your hand across your shoulder to brush away the mistake, and "wave goodbye" in softball and baseball by taking off your cap momentarily as if to wave away the mistake prior to putting the hat back on (Thompson, 2003).
4. Avoid sarcasm and negative body language. Sarcasm isn't humor. It's hostility, and it makes people feel bad. In particular, young athletes often don't understand sarcasm. It may feel like veiled criticism, and it often is. Speak directly and honestly, without resorting to sarcasm, which is a negative communication habit.

   Similarly, be constantly aware of your body language. As a coach, you are on display, and you are the model for your program. Without realizing it, your attitude about or response to a bad play can be conveyed by your eye-rolling, dropping or shaking your head, or putting your face in your hands. Be the positive expression and body language that your athletes need to see at all times.

Sending Messages High in Information

Some coaches seem to think that a whistle, a cap, and the title Coach qualify them to be the Judge. They constantly give verdicts to their players, telling them what they did right or wrong—usually wrong. Athletes need more than to be told that they did something wrong; they need specific information about how to do it right. Successful coaches are not judges; they are skilled teachers.

Some coaches communicate like the Judge for the same reasons they adopt the negative approach—sheer habit and imitation of other coaches who engage in this practice. Other coaches become judges because they lack the technical knowledge of the sport necessary to give athletes the information they need. When this occurs, coaches may become judges to cover up their own deficiencies. Command-style coaches are especially likely to communicate like the Judge.

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Recommendations for Being an Informational Coach

1. Send messages high in information. Provide information in clear, concise, specific language. Evaluate each of your messages by asking the question, "Did my message allow the athlete to learn?" In the following messages listed, note the precise information provided in the second column as compared to the general (judge-like) information provided in the first column:

General (judge-like) feedback	Specific informational feedback
"You were out of position."	"You have to jump to front the cutter when she cuts middle."
"Good job."	"Good decision to feed the right-side hitter against that defense."
"Move your hands higher."	"Move your hands next to your ears."

   Imprecise praise like "Good job" is common in sport, but positive reinforcement and performance feedback are much more effective when they're linked to specific behaviors. Research on the communication skills of successful coaches found that their messages to athletes were loaded with information, as opposed to being simply evaluative (Becker & Wrisberg, 2008; Erickson et al., 2011).



Do you provide feedback that is high in information?
Derek Davis/Portland Press Herald via Getty Images

2. Be certain you understand the reason for your athletes' actions before you judge their behavior. Being a judge is dangerous because you assume you always know what is good and bad, right and wrong. Too often, judgmental coaches label something as bad or wrong, only to learn later that *they* were wrong.

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Consider the following example: Doug is late to practice, so Coach Stanley makes him run 15 laps as punishment without letting him explain. Later, Coach Stanley learns that the boy's mother was late getting home from work and that he was responsible for babysitting his little sister. Under these circumstances, the athlete behaved responsibly.

3. Focus your comments on the athletes' behaviors, not on them as people. Rather than saying to an athlete who has made a tactical error, "What's wrong with you, Noah?" say, "That was the wrong decision in that situation, Noah. Remember to look the runner back prior to throwing to first base," commenting only on the behavior.
4. Don't overreact to simple mistakes that athletes make. Have you ever seen a basketball coach erupt in histrionics to lament the fact that a player dribbled the ball off his foot? Everyone in the arena understands that this was an uncharacteristic, simple mistake that probably won't happen again. Coaches need to keep in mind that sport tends to evaluate participants enough through competition. Usually athletes know when they have made a mistake or played poorly. Players hardly need to be told they made an error when the ball goes between their legs and the game-winning run scores. A better action from the coach would be to smile to support and encourage the athlete for the embarrassing mistake that they are all too aware of making.

What a Coach Can Teach a Teacher

Researchers analyzed the communication and teaching practices of legendary UCLA basketball coach John Wooden, who won 10 national championships and is widely considered the greatest teacher of basketball in history (Gallimore & Tharp, 2004; Tharp & Gallimore, 1976). Coach Wooden's comments to his players were short, punctuated, and numerous—there were no lengthy lectures. His demonstrations rarely lasted longer than three seconds.

Approximately 75 percent of all his utterances carried information, with only 7 percent of his communication being praises and another 7 percent being scolds. The majority of his scolds were embedded with instructions, and this communication combination was named a "Wooden" in honor of the famous coach. An example would be, "I have been telling you for three years not to wind up when you pass the ball. Pass from the chest!" Another example: "Move your feet into position. You can't reach in and take the ball from a good guard—quit reaching! Move your feet and get in front to cut him off."

A former player recalled Coach Wooden's communication effectiveness:

As [someone] who committed many errors during practice and therefore having been the recipient of plenty of corrections, it was the information I received during the correction that I needed most.

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What a Coach Can Teach a Teacher *(continued)*

I could then make the adjustments and changes needed. Had the majority of Coach Wooden's [communication] been positive ("Good job") or negative ("No, that's not the way"), I would have been left with an evaluation, not a solution. Also, correction in the form of information did not address or attack me as a person. Information was aimed at the act, rather than the actor. (Gallimore & Tharp, 2004, p. 128)

Communicating With Consistency

Communicating with consistency is a real challenge because all of us have a little Coach Fickle in us. It is easy to preach one thing and do another, or to do one thing one day and the opposite the next. Your brain may tell you to say one thing verbally, but your emotions may express something else nonverbally. When youngsters receive these mixed messages, they become confused or question your credibility.

Look at it from the perspective of the athletes. A coach asks them to show emotional control when playing, but then the coach throws a temper tantrum at an official. A coach asks players to respect their teammates but treats them without respect. A coach teaches that physical fitness is important but does nothing to stay fit. A coach penalizes a bench-sitter for being late to practice and then ignores the same behavior by a starting player. Inconsistent communication from coaches creates anxiety in athletes and destroys team morale.

Recommendations for Communicating With Consistency

1. Consistency starts with your philosophy and objectives, and you must run your program consistent with these. Repeatedly clarify the objectives and expectations for your program to keep your team vision visible and as an inspirational focus. Coaches whose communication patterns change according to their moods are ineffective communicators. As previously discussed, when you promise to do something be sure to follow through. It's important to be consistent in your professional and personal behavior based on your philosophy and vision and who you say you are.
2. Be honest and forthright when talking to athletes and be loyal to those individuals who are not present. One of the worst ethical mistakes a coach can make is to talk about others in derogatory ways when they are not present. Would you trust someone who does this?
3. Consistently model the attitudes and actions that you want your athletes to show as part of your team culture. No matter your mood or what is going on in your life, show up for practices and team events with enthusiasm and positivity, showing that you love being there. Maintain the commitments you're asking your athletes to make in such things as fitness, nutrition, and promptness. Mentally

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prepare for competition so that you prime yourself to respond professionally at all times to officials and opponents.



Consistency in communication builds trust.
CasarsaGuru/E+/Getty Images

Learning How to Listen

Hearing is automatic; listening is not. Listening involves a deep desire to understand and connect, and it takes effort and sincere caring. True listening means we make ourselves available to others by suspending our needs, and by giving them our complete attention.

Most of us take the skill of listening for granted. We all think we do it well. The truth, however, is that very few people are excellent listeners. It's so easy to do other things while pretending to listen or assuming that you actually are listening. It is one of the most important skills that you can develop as a coach and human being.

Recommendations for Being a Better Listener

1. Practice active listening. Communication books advocate active listening, which involves interacting with athletes to show them that you understand. Here are some examples of how it works:

   One of your players is worried about meeting your expectations for an important game.

   PLAYER: "Do you think we can beat this team?"

   COACH: "They are a pretty good team, but we have a good team too."

   PLAYER: "But what if we don't play well?"

   Now you must interpret these questions. Is she really worried about the team winning, or is she worried that she may not be able to play well enough herself?

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In active listening, you don't just guess at your player's meaning; you work to find it out. You do this by feeding back to the player what you think she means:

> *COACH: "Are you worried about how you might play?"*
>
> *PLAYER: "Well, a little."*
>
> *COACH: "You've trained hard and are prepared; play the best you can, and that's all I ask."*

The coach's reassurance lets the player know that her acceptance on the team is not contingent on her performing well, but only on her trying. Here is another example:

> *GYMNAST: "What's the worst injury you've seen on the high bar?"*
>
> *COACH: "I saw a gymnast fly off and break his neck."*

The coach may have answered the question without thinking about what was really being asked. The athlete may have been expressing concern about the possibility of his own injury. Active listening by the coach might change the conversation this way:

> *GYMNAST: "What's the worst injury you've seen on the high bar?"*
>
> *COACH: "I haven't seen too many injuries. Are you worried about getting hurt?"*
>
> *GYMNAST: "Sometimes I think about it."*
>
> *COACH: "With today's better equipment, the use of a spotter, and the coaching you've received, the chances of serious injury are really small."*

Active listening is a tremendous skill that connects you solidly with your athletes. Respond actively by maintaining eye contact, nodding, and sometimes asking questions for clarification. Because active listening lets athletes know that you under-stand and respect their ideas and feelings, they will be more willing to listen to you in return.

2. Hustle to listen, just like you ask your athletes to hustle. It's not easy to listen, especially when we're tired or busy. We've all developed interpersonal habits that derail active listening, such as filtering or pretending to listen. Mentally prepare to listen by narrowing your focus and increasing your concentration on the speaker. Then maintain a single-minded focus on the speaker, without pulling your attention away to distractions.
3. Don't interrupt your athletes. A U.S. Gallup poll found interrupting to be the most irritating communication block (Tuhovsky, 2015). We sometimes interrupt others because we anticipate what they will say and complete their thoughts for them. Then we respond to what we thought they were going to say, but perhaps later discover that the intended message was quite different. It's especially tempting to

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interrupt those who speak slowly because we are too impatient to wait for them to complete their messages. Remember that you can listen considerably faster than a person can speak.

4. Respect your athletes' rights to provide you feedback. A key communication skill for coaches is the ability to receive feedback in a productive manner. It's difficult for all of us to receive critical feedback about ourselves, but the trick is to accept the discomfort and honestly attempt to understand the feedback being given to us. The listening blocks of defensiveness and being right occur in some coaches, particularly command-style coaches. Being right means that coaches will go to any lengths to avoid being wrong (even if they are). This type of coach can't take critical feedback, can't be corrected, and refuses to accept suggestions. Here are some guidelines for receiving feedback:

    - Don't argue—seek to understand the message. Be quiet and listen!
    - Ask questions to clarify and allow for understanding (e.g., "When does that happen?" "Could you tell me more about that situation?").
    - Be open-minded and ask the person giving feedback for suggestions for more productive strategies.
    - Thank the person for the feedback. Remember that giving feedback takes courage (especially athlete to coach) and can be just as difficult as receiving it.

    Listening well and accepting feedback does not mean that the coach must agree with what an athlete is saying. Coaches should listen carefully to obtain all the information, consider the information, and then respond. Athletes should know that they have a voice, they are heard, and their input is important and appreciated, but that in most cases, the coach makes the final decision.

Improving Your Nonverbal Communication

Many of us mistakenly assume that the verbal portion of communication is the most important aspect of the message. Actually, the verbal content of any message makes up just 7 percent of the total message sent to another person. The other 93 percent of the message comes from nonverbal behavior such as body position, tone of voice, and facial expressions (Hartley & Karinch, 2017). Nonverbal behavior often overshadows actual verbal comments in media reports and voter impressions of televised U.S. presidential debates (Bucy & Stewart, 2018). Research has shown that facial expressions, body language, and gestures are strongly influential factors for athletes when forming initial impressions about a coach (Manley et al., 2008).

Consider the effective body language displayed in practice by successful professional basketball coach Steve Kerr: "Rather than barking orders, or standing with arms crossed —typical postures of authority—Kerr moved around the court, checking on players, sharing a joke, a subtle touch on the shoulder, or a quick tip. When Kerr listened, he turned his whole body, leaning in" (Ballard, 2017, p. 34).

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Recommendations for Enhancing Your Nonverbal Skills

1. Make your verbal and nonverbal messages congruent. If your spoken message and your body language are mismatched, athletes will respond to the nonverbal message every time. For example, if you verbally support an athlete who just made a crucial mental error, your body language and facial expression should be congruent with your supportive message. Gestures speak louder than words.
2. Provide meaningful and comfortable eye contact with your athletes. You connect with your athletes with your eyes. Meet their gaze, but don't stare and don't make it a "who blinks first" glare of aggressiveness.
3. Model and teach a strong, confident, enthusiastic posture. Like it or not, as the coach, you are on display, and you model how you want your athletes to act. Mentally rehearse and practice this and intentionally engage in strong posture in all coaching situations. Lead the way in congratulating opposing teams after both victories and losses. Model professional responses when your team is treated unfairly.
4. Show athletes how you want them to behave after having played well and not so well, and after having won or lost. Work with your athletes to teach them the nonverbal poise and confidence that you want them to display during warm-ups and competition. Research shows that athletes gain confidence by observing the negative, defeated nonverbal behavior and posture of opponents during competition (Furley & Schweizer, 2014). Assess their body language in training and competition, and even video-record athletes, to increase their self-awareness of the messages they are sending with their bodies. Likewise, coaches can learn a lot from observing their body language on film.
5. Read and ask questions about the nonverbal signals from your athletes. Often your athletes won't verbally express frustration or confusion, but it is evident in their body language. This is a good time to check in with them with questions like, "How are we doing?" or "I feel like something's not working—can you give me some feedback?"

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